

position, essentially telling his opponent, 'Let's solve problems on the board, and I'm confident I'll do it better than you.'" This high-risk, high-reward approach has been tried before, yet, as Anand explains, "When it goes wrong, it can go quite badly wrong. But Arjun has been testing boundaries of chess in almost every game."

While Arjun may not be the most talked-about Indian prodigy compared to R. Praggnanandhaa and D. Gukesh, who often shine in high-stakes tournaments, he has carved his own path. **For the man from Warangal, it's all about making a decision and pursuing it with full commitment — the grind, for him, never stops.**

Arjun is enjoying a breakout year, winning several major Open tournaments. He started with a victory at the Menorca Open in April and continued his streak with a dominant performance at the Stepan Avagyan Memorial 2024, clinching the title with a round to spare. Reflecting on his achievements in a conversation with *Sportstar*, Arjun shares, "This year has been going super well, I must say. Not just the

results, but also my number of losses was very limited — only three. I can clearly see that my quality of play has been quite good, and it's improving over time. I'm seeing a stronger version of myself."

His stellar year includes a second-place finish at the TePe Sigeman Chess Tournament and a joint-fifth spot at the Sharjah Masters Open. His incredible 10/11 performance on Board 3 earned him both individual and team gold for India at the Budapest Chess Olympiad. Capping it all off, he claimed the WR Chess Masters Cup 2024 in London, outplaying a world-class field that included Anand, Alireza Firouzja, Nodirbek Abdusattorov, Maxime Vachier-Lagrave, Praggnanandhaa, and Vidit Gujrathi.

After coming close to breaking the elusive 2800-rating mark multiple times, Arjun finally achieved it during the European Chess Club Cup. In the fifth round, playing for Team Alkaloid, he defeated Russia's Dmitry Andreikin to become the 16th player in history to cross the threshold. Yet, the milestone itself took a back seat for Arjun. "When I crossed 2800, it felt

nice, but I was happier about beating a strong player. Once the tournament was over, I wasn't still in the 2800 club. Not that it made me upset or anything; it just feels nice to join a list with the greats like Anand sir, Magnus Carlsen, and others," he says.

Anand also echoes Arjun's sentiments on the rating. He says, "For me, this fixation on a number obscures the point. Had he stopped at 2799, would it be less impressive? What stands out is the journey. He started the year almost 80 points behind and climbed steadily with single-minded focus, navigating high-stakes tournaments with narrow margins for error. The way he did it is incredibly significant. For me, the way he's done it is more impressive, and yes, 2800 places him in a very small, elite group."

Arjun's success story has been anything but sudden. Ranked World No. 4, he endured several heart-wrenching setbacks in 2023, ultimately missing out on qualifying for the 2024 Candidates Tournament, a historic event featuring three Indians — Vidit, Gukesh, and Praggnanandhaa — marking the first

Arjun Erigaisi's rating progression

